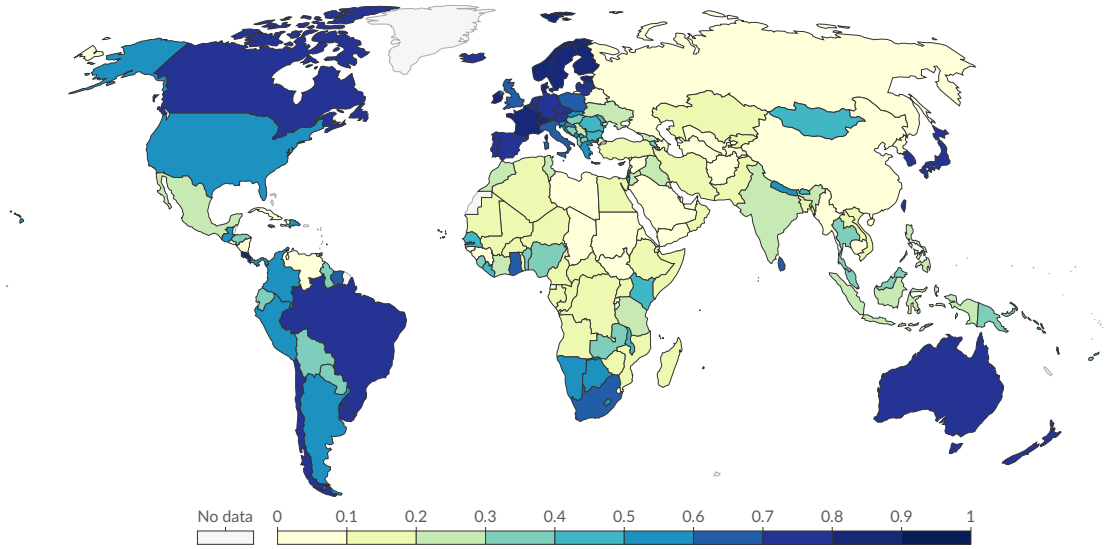
Liberal Democracy Index 2025

Data by V-Dem. Expert estimates of the extent of voting rights, the freedom and fairness of elections, freedoms of association and expression, civil liberties, and executive constraints. The index ranges from 0 to 1 (most democratic).

Our World in Data

Table | Map | Line | +4



1789 — 2025

Data source: V-Dem (2026) – Learn more about this data

OurWorldinData.org/democracy | CC BY

Download | Share | Enter full-screen

Related: How do different approaches score democracy across the world?

SELECT COUNTRIES

Search for a count

Sort by: Liberal de

Filter by type: All

- Taiwan
- Asia
- Denmark
- Sweden
- Norway
- Switzerland
- Estonia
- Ireland
- Costa Rica
- Finland
- France
- Belgium
- Czechia
- Australia

What you should know about this indicator

- This index, produced by Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem), is useful if you are interested in big and small differences in democracy, want scores for almost all countries, and prefer a narrow understanding of democracy. For data that focuses on big differences in political systems or has a broad understanding of

LIBERAL DEMOCRACY INDEX
V-DEM

democracy, other sources will be more useful. You can explore these alternatives in our Key Democracy Charts and Democracy Data Explorer.

- It takes a narrow view of democracy by focusing on electoral (free and fair elections) and liberal political institutions (civil rights and protection from the state).
- The index is based mainly on assessments by V-Dem's country experts. It also uses some factual information coded by its own researchers.
- It is made up of eight sub-indices: the share of adult citizens who have the right to vote, elected officials, free and fair elections, freedom of expression, freedom of association, legislative constraints on the executive, judicial constraints on the executive, and individual liberties and equality before the law.
- V-Dem covers many more countries since 1900, which affects regional averages.
- We provide two kinds of regional averages: **country averages** and **population-weighted averages**. Country averages weigh each country equally and give a sense of how the typical country is doing. Population-weighted averages weigh countries with larger populations more and therefore better reflect the average person's experience.

How is this data described by its producer - V-Dem? +

Central estimate of the extent of suffrage, the freedom and fairness of elections, freedoms of association and expression, individual and minority rights, equality before the law, and executive constraints.

Source
V-Dem (2026) – processed by Our World in Data

Last updated
March 17, 2026

Next expected update
March 2027

Date range
1789–2025

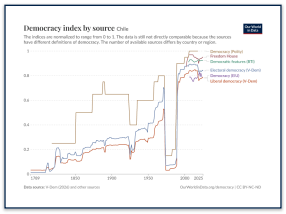
Related research and writing



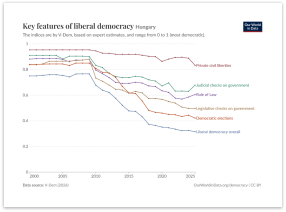
Democracy data: how sources differ and when to use which one
Bastian Herre

People around the world have gained democratic rights, but some have many more rights than others
Bastian Herre

Explore charts that include this data



Democracy index by source



Key features of liberal democracy

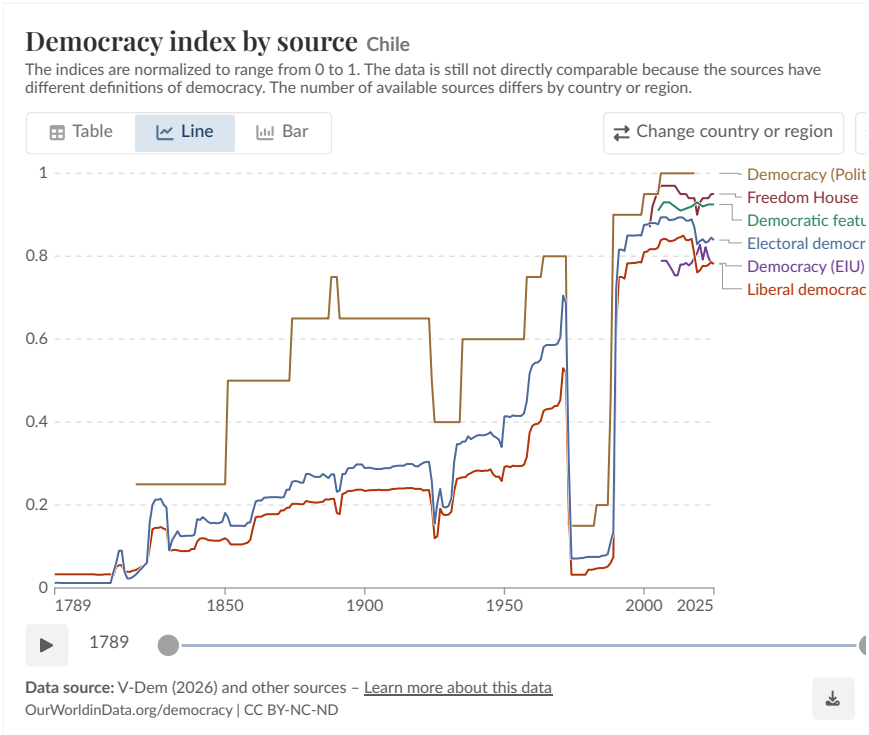


Chart 1 of 3

Sources and processing

This data is based on the following sources

V-Dem – Democracy report

The Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) project publishes data and research on democracy and human rights.

It acknowledges that democracy can be characterized differently and measures electoral, liberal, participatory, deliberative, and egalitarian characterizations of

How we process data at Our World in Data

All data and visualizations on Our World in Data rely on data sourced from one or several original data providers. Preparing this original data involves several processing steps. Depending on the data, this can include standardizing country names and world region definitions, converting units, calculating derived indicators such as per capita measures, as well as adding or adapting metadata such as the name or the description given to an indicator.

At the link below you can find a detailed description of the structure of our data pipeline, including links to all the code used to prepare data across Our World in Data.

Read about our data pipeline →

NOTES ON OUR PROCESSING STEP FOR THIS INDICATOR

Region aggregates

The default regional aggregates (including values for the World) have been estimated by averaging the country values. These are only estimated when data for most countries and populations is available (i.e. 70% for most continents). We have used the list of countries in 1900 as a reference.

In addition, regional aggregates with names like "Region (population-weighted)" (including values for World) have been estimated by averaging the country values weighted by population. The population values are from the UN WPP 2024 revision dataset. These are only estimated when 70% of people in region have data for the given year.

Data imputation

We expand the years covered by V-Dem further: To expand the time coverage of today's countries and include more of the period when they were still non-sovereign territories, we identified the historical entity they were a part of and used that regime's data whenever available

For example, V-Dem only provides regime data since Bangladesh's independence in 1971. There is, however, regime data for Pakistan and the colony of India, both of which the current territory of Bangladesh was a part. We, therefore, use the regime data of Pakistan for Bangladesh from 1947 to 1970, and the regime data of India from 1789 to 1946. We did so for all countries with a past or current population of more than one million.

For more details on the imputation methodology and which countries are affected, refer to this file.

Reuse this work

- All data produced by third-party providers and made available by Our World in Data are subject to the license terms from the original providers. Our work would not be possible without the data providers we rely on, so we ask you to always cite them appropriately (see below). This is crucial to allow data providers to continue doing their work, enhancing, maintaining and updating valuable data.
- All data, visualizations, and code produced by Our World in Data are completely open access under the Creative Commons BY license. You have the permission to use, distribute, and reproduce these in any medium, provided the source and authors are credited.

Citations

HOW TO CITE THIS PAGE

To cite this page overall, including any descriptions, FAQs or explanations of the data authored by Our World in Data, please use the following citation:

> "Data Page: Liberal democracy index", part of the following publication: Bastian Herre, Lucas Rodés-Guirao, and Esteban Ortiz-Ospina (2013) - "Democracy". Data adapted from V-Dem. Retrieved from https://archive.ourworldindata.org/20260806-091206/grapher/liberal-democracy-index.html [online resource] (archived on August 6, 2026).

HOW TO CITE THIS DATA

In-line citation

If you have limited space (e.g. in data visualizations), you can use this abbreviated in-line citation:

> V-Dem (2026) – processed by Our World in Data

Full citation

> V-Dem (2026) – processed by Our World in Data. "Liberal democracy index – V-Dem" [dataset]. V-Dem, "Democracy report v16" [original data]. Retrieved October 26, 2026 from https://archive.ourworldindata.org/20260806-091206/grapher/liberal-democracy-index.html (archived on August 6, 2026).

Download

QUICK DOWNLOAD

Download the data shown in this chart as a ZIP file containing a CSV file, metadata in JSON format, and a README. The CSV file can be opened in Excel, Google Sheets, and other data analysis tools.

Download full data
Includes all entities and time points

Download displayed data
Includes only the entities and time points currently visible in the chart

DATA API

Use these URLs to programmatically access this chart's data and configure your requests with the options below. Our documentation provides more information on how to use the API, and you can find a few code examples below.

- (•) Download full data, including all entities and time points
- ( ) Download only the currently selected data visible in the chart

Data URL (CSV format)

```
https://ourworldindata.org/grapher/liberal-democracy-index.csv?v=1&csvType=full&useColumnShortNames=false
```

Metadata URL (JSON format)

```
https://ourworldindata.org/grapher/liberal-democracy-index.metadata.json?v=1&csvType=full&useColumnShortNames=false
```

Code examples

Examples of how to load this data into different data analysis tools. +

Our World in Data is free and accessible for everyone.

Help us do this work by making a donation.

Donate now